Prismonaut · Game Design Document

Momentum redesign of Prismonaut (Naked Dog) · Design document by Andrés Ruiz Palomino (Arzpal)

Prismonaut is a **momentum platformer with a semi-linear metroidvania structure**: an alien clone crashes on the planet it came to plunder, discovers that it is the villain, and in the end chooses between staying to repair that world or leaving with the prisms that ruined it.

Speed is the game's central resource. It builds up, is conserved, multiplies or is lost depending on how you chain forms and geometry; it opens walls, decides routes and scales the damage you take.

Visual direction: pure 2D, with the treatment of *Hollow Knight* and *Silksong*: using depth in parts of the environment so the world feels alive instead of a flat background.

Premise

Prismo is a disposable clone from an alien civilization that manufactures Prismonauts to travel to other planets, steal their natural resources and bring them back.

As it enters this planet's atmosphere its ship fails, crashes and breaks into pieces on the ice volcano. The impact damages Prismo and its companion AI, and both forget what they came for.

On reaching the wreckage of the ship it recovers the key piece of information: it came to harvest. It decides to do exactly that while it looks for the pieces of its ship scattered across the biomes, with the idea of repairing it and using the prisms' energy to leave.

What it discovers along the way is that its civilization ruins worlds, and that this planet was already ruined by a worse one. In the end it can choose: stay to repair the planet, or leave taking the prisms with it.

The companion AI travels with it the whole game and is responsible for the laser, the holograms, the tutorial and practically all the on-screen help. Its own amnesia justifies the player learning the world's rules at the same pace as the character.

Neither of the two is the good option, and that is the point. Taking the prisms is the selfish act it was built for, and also the only way to leave the planet's dormant empire without a power source. Staying to repair is the sacrifice, and also leaving the prisms within reach of those who are learning to command them. The player cannot know which one saves the world.

The thematic hook: the prisms are both your fuel and the world's antagonist. Getting close to one and taking part of its energy gives you the charge, at no moral cost. Taking it is something else: the three prisms are the ship's fuel. They don't make you stronger. They make it possible to leave.

That is the piece that holds up the game's whole decision. The prisms are not an optional power reward that the optimal player always grabs, nor a moral punishment that the decent player always refuses: they are the ticket home, and giving up even one of them already means staying.

The world and the three prisms

The prisms are not minerals: they are creations of an alien civilization different from Prismo's, and far more dangerous. That civilization doesn't steal planets, it inherits them.

Its method is a generational handover. The prism generates abundant energy and, while a civilization uses it, it contaminates its mind and heart. Then they send capsules with their young, who, once adopted by the prisms, absorb their energy, learn to command the crystal network and end up ruling the planet.

The Collapse: the First Exposure

Long before Prismo arrived, an ancient civilization of scientists devoted its research to the prisms. To survive their influence they discovered **Ashlar**, a native mineral able to repel their frequency, and protected themselves with pendants made of it.

That research unleashed the **First Exposure**: a massive pulse with which the prisms tried to assimilate the neural network of every life form. The protocol failed when one scientist lost their pendant. The infection was immediate and spread like a virus, turning the scientists into extensions of the prisms' will.

That is the mistake that holds up the whole game. The Exposure didn't happen when it was meant to: the scientists' curiosity triggered it prematurely and artificially, altering the cosmic timeline. When the Children's capsules landed, there was nothing left to draw them to the prisms.

The **Guardians**, companions and protectors of those scientists, refused to attack those they had loved, and fled the conversion toward the planet's most inhospitable lands: the ice volcanoes, which are also where Ashlar comes from. There they found the capsules.

The three civilizations and their prisms

Three prisms fell in separate places. None of the three civilizations caused the disaster: each one is a different reaction to a disaster that had already happened.

CIVILIZATION	WHAT IT DID WITH ITS PRISM	HOW IT ENDED UP
Ciudad Olvidada (the Forgotten City)	Used it to the full to advance technologically	Corrupted completely. It caused most of the world's disasters and went extinct
Solarpunk Forest	Used it deeply, saw the corruption in time and got rid of it	Locked it away. For decades it has lived off sustainable technology in the uncorrupted half of its biome
Crystal Mines / El Dorado	Never used it. Being less developed, they took it for a god and put it on an altar	Intact and naive. They worship the most dangerous object on the planet without knowing it

The Ciudad Olvidada prism is no longer in the city: it ended up in **Gamarra Tecnológico**, where the Moles experiment with it without fully understanding what it is.

The Guardians and the Children

This is the piece the player meets first and understands last.

The Guardians protect the Children with the only shield they know: Ashlar. They are the community's physical strength and life support, and they give them shelter and sustenance in the extreme climate. To keep up with children who launch themselves through the air without weighing the risk, they developed fast-travel hooks with the silk they secrete. **They are the ones who teach Prismo the hook.**

The Children didn't arrive by accident. They are the lineage sent to be the planet's definitive sovereigns, and only the premature Exposure stopped the prisms from adopting them. They are immune to them, they have psychic powers they can't control, and they see the world as a playground. Under the Guardians' care they channel those powers into architecture, thermal agriculture and the defence of a secret civilization.

The irony is the key to the game. What the Guardians experience as a rescue is, from the original plan, a kidnapping: they are keeping the planet's future lords away from their power source. And the mother species watches with satisfaction, because the First Exposure already gave it control of much of the world, and it considers this upbringing a better experiment: let the Children discover their nature on their own, so their rise is authentic.

Every time a Child uses its powers to build, it strengthens a capacity that one day could claim control of every prism on the planet. That is the game's only present-day threat, and it is invisible, slow and adorable.

The Moles

Small, very jealous scavengers from Gamarra Tecnológico. You see them in passing on the ice volcano recovering minerals to sell in their biome, and they dig to escape as soon as they run into Prismo.

That they steal Ashlar from the volcano and at the same time experiment with a prism in Gamarra is no coincidence: **Ashlar is the only thing that lets them handle one without dying.** That is their motivation, their technology and the boss of stop 6.

The state of the world when Prismo lands

- **Ice Volcano:** a frozen zone of cryogenic rock and liquid nitrogen, with unique adapted flora and great mineral wealth. Practically inhospitable except for the Guardians and the Children. Its deep half is unknown to Prismo.
- **Ciudad Olvidada:** a ruin with no inhabitants.
- **Solarpunk Forest:** decades building renewable technology. Its biome is split into the pure half and the corrupted one.
- **Gamarra Tecnológico:** a huge market of a civilization that builds with the scrap it loots from Ciudad Olvidada.
- **The Geysers:** poisoned indirectly by the ventilation of the radioactive city, which comes out through them.

The game's route

The structure is **semi-linear by biome**: each biome opens the next, with backtracking allowed.

Vocabulary: a *biome* is a place; a *stop* is a step along the route. The route is **thirteen stops over eight biomes**, because five biomes are visited twice.

STOP	PLACE	ROLE IN THE ROUTE
1	Ice Volcano	Tutorial. The ship crashes. You meet the Guardians and the Children, who seem to be orphans. They teach you the hook. The deep half stays closed
2	Solarpunk Forest	The first civilization that explains to you what the prisms are. You help with their sustainable technology and they ask you to take theirs far away. **Prism 1**
3	Geysers	A remote zone already poisoned by something you can't see yet
4	Chernobyl / acid rain	The source of the poison. First glimpse of the world's real damage
5	Geysers	Revisit: with what you learned in Chernobyl, the biome reads differently
6	Gamarra Tecnológico	Scrap market. Boss of the Moles, and you snatch the prism they experiment with, without knowing yet where it comes from. First visit to the labs, where you learn Fusion. **Prism 2**
7	Crystal Mines / El Dorado	An innocent civilization that worships its prism on an altar. You meet the people and touch the prism: **+1 charge**. You don't take it yet
8	Basalt / Labyrinths	Avoided by everyone. The highest density of puzzles and the only passage to the final stretch
9	Ciudad Olvidada	The guilty one. You discover where the prism you carry came from
10	Gamarra Tecnológico	Revisit: you go back to the labs
11	Solarpunk Forest	Revisit. Closure with the civilization that did know when to stop
12	Crystal Mines / El Dorado	You come back for the whole prism, knowing what you would do to them. **The decision**
13	Ice Volcano	Climax. The unknown half opens: who the Children really were

The game begins and ends in the same place, with the same people. You meet the Children in the tutorial as adorable orphans and come back at the end to understand what they were about to become. The volcano has to read in two different ways (with two charges and three forms, and with the full kit), and that shapes its level design from day one.

The revisits are not filler: each one comes after the biome that explains the previous one. Chernobyl explains the geysers, Ciudad Olvidada explains what you took from the Moles, and El Dorado is visited twice so the decision has somewhere to land.

The escalation of the three prisms

PRISM	BIOME	STOP	HOW YOU GET IT
1	Solarpunk Forest	2	It is given to you. They ask you to take it far away
2	Gamarra Tecnológico	6	You snatch it from some scrappers. Boss. You don't know where it comes from until stop 9
3	Crystal Mines	7 and 12	You touch it at 7. You steal it at 12, from people who treated you well

Given, fought over, stolen. The moral cost rises at every step without anyone having to explain it, and the horror of the second one is retroactive: in Ciudad Olvidada you discover that what you are carrying is the prism that killed an entire city.

The third one is visited twice. Touching and taking don't just mean different things: they happen at different moments. At stop 7 you meet those people and take a sliver of energy from their god, so little they don't even notice. At stop 12 you come back for the whole god. The moral escalation happens inside El Dorado, and the fifth charge arrives halfway through the route.

The prisms are the ship's fuel

They are not a power reward. They are what makes the ship fly, and therefore the key to the ending.

IF YOU TAKE	WHAT HAPPENS
All three	You can leave. And you leave the dormant empire without a power source
Fewer than three	You stay. And you leave the prisms within reach of those who are learning to command them

This keeps the decision from collapsing toward one side. If taking the prisms gave power, the optimal player would always take them. If it gave nothing, nobody would take them, because nobody does the worst thing in exchange for nothing. Tied to the ending, both options cost something enormous and neither is taken on autopilot. And it turns the third one into the hardest moment of the game: stealing from innocent people the god they worship, knowing exactly what you need it for.

The core: speed

The rule everything in the game hangs from:

> **Input only accelerates up to cruising speed (8 m/s).** Above that, the stick doesn't accelerate: it only changes how much resistance you suffer. **Extra speed comes from the forms and from geometry, never from holding a direction**, and above cruising speed resistance gradually spends it.

That turns the player into someone who manages momentum instead of someone who runs. **Running is free and limited; going fast is a decision you pay for and earn.**

Conservation rules

- **No hard speed cap.** Above cruising speed there is resistance, as in reality: the surface's friction plus an air resistance that grows with the square of the speed, on the ground and in the air. Going with it reduces it without cancelling it; going against it increases it, without ever braking abruptly.
- **No automatic braking when you release the stick.** Only slow surface friction.
- **Landing keeps 100% of horizontal speed.**
- **Slopes really accelerate:** gravity is projected onto the surface.
- **Free fall settles at a fixed speed (24 m/s)** because gravity stops adding, but any force can exceed it.

Damage scales with speed

The other half of the core is that **speed also kills you**.

```
harmful object = D_obj% × (1 + v × 0.10)
firm object    = 2% × (1 + v × 0.075)
```

`D_obj` is the base damage of each harmful object, and it is defined object by object. The firm object only deals damage on a perpendicular impact and above a minimum speed: grazing a wall at full speed isn't punished, crashing into it head-on is.

The player is rewarded and punished for the same thing, so **every zone has a readable speed band in which going fast is clearly the right play.** If the punishment outweighed the reward, they would learn to go slow and the game would switch itself off.

The thresholds the player reads

Speed is not a decorative number: it is a key with visible steps.

SPEED	WHAT IT OPENS
< 12 m/s	Nothing. Cruising (8 m/s) doesn't reach it: walking never breaks anything
12 m/s	Resistance level 1. It asks for a charge: running plus a Circle gives 18 m/s
18 m/s	Resistance level 2. A charge and something more: a ramp or a bounce
26 m/s	Resistance level 3. Only at high speeds, more than three times cruising

The three resistance levels are the vocabulary with which the level tells the player how much speed they need to bring.

Free fall has a fixed speed, but forces don't

Gravity stops adding once natural falling speed is reached, so that jumping from a medium height doesn't shoot Prismo off. But that is not a cap: any force can exceed it, and that speed is conserved. So a downward drill, a dash or a bounce generate falls much faster than gravity alone would, and that speed is still convertible: bouncing with the Circle to shoot off horizontally, or reaching the bottom with enough m/s to break something with the Square.

Stored kinetic energy

It is the bridge between the movement core and the puzzle layer. Speed doesn't only open doors: **it can be stored.** There are objects that capture momentum and turn it into a source of energy usable later.

The speedometer. It sticks to Prismo for a while and keeps asking it to reach a minimum speed that keeps rising. If Prismo can't keep up, it explodes: it deals damage, breaks, and you have to start over. It stores all that kinetic energy and later becomes the energy source for certain puzzles. It does three things at once: it forces you to really run, it punishes with damage instead of an abstract failure, and it turns a run into a resource the player carries.

The hook generator. Prismo spins around with the hook using its speed, like a stationary bike, and generates kinetic energy as long as it keeps spinning. It is the slow sibling of the speedometer: one asks for a run and the other for a sustained rotation. Between the two they cover both ways of having speed, linear and angular, and they feed the same kind of puzzle.

Abilities

One button per form. No selector or wheel: the game is about execution, not menus. The forms aim in eight directions with the stick and, with no direction, use the current direction of travel.

The three forms (from the start)

FORM	WHAT IT DOES	THE RULE IT TEACHES	COST
Circle	A short dash (0.2 s) that adds 10 m/s as a vector to your movement: falling and aiming right, you come out diagonally. Against any solid surface except spikes it bounces like a mirror: the part of the speed that hits head-on comes out ×1.3 and the part parallel to the surface is kept	Speed comes from chaining bounces, not from the button. Geometry pays more than the button	1 charge
Square	Block and parry, held down: it lasts up to 0.6 s or until you release. Repels moving objects ×1.15, blocks stationary harmful objects and breaks obstacles if you arrive above their resistance	Breaking depends on the speed you arrive at, not on pressing	1 charge

FORM	WHAT IT DOES	THE RULE IT TEACHES	COST
Triangle	Drill. A burst in eight directions that never slows down (the greater of your speed and 16 m/s). Goes through drillable terrain; holding it speeds you up inside	Straight out, you leave ×1.5. Turning inside burns the bonus	1 charge

The Circle is short on purpose: its value isn't the distance, it is changing direction while gaining speed. Since it adds to what you were already carrying, it combines with any movement: if you are diving and cast it to the right, you come out diagonally down-right; and if that diagonal hits a sloped wall head-on, you bounce the opposite way, up-left.

The bounce only multiplies the part that hits head-on: bouncing off the ground launches you higher without speeding you up horizontally, and a wall sends you back faster without giving you height. A bounce doesn't give the charge back: what you gain by chaining is speed, and over time the player discovers that connecting abilities opens other paths.

The forms' impulse is briefly invulnerable. The dash and the bounce keep their direction for an instant with no gravity or resistance, and then gravity, resistance and control come back gradually instead of dropping in all at once. The Triangle works the same way when its burst ends or when it leaves the rock.

The Square bleeds speed while it is active. That is what keeps spamming it from being dominant: the Square is the only form that doesn't generate speed, it only conserves it, and if it also charged nothing for conserving it, the optimal player would always be blocking. With friction active during the block, holding it is literally trading speed for safety.

The ones that unlock

ABILITY	WHAT IT ADDS
Hook	A chain to authorized anchors while you hold the button. Air only. Consumes Hook Fuel, not charges
Double jump	Height and correction in the air. Opens vertical routes that were closed before
Horizontal dash	A medium-long forward move. Goes through things and generates starting speed from a standstill
Holograms	Generate small hazards or aids on the terrain by spending materials from the inventory. Obtained through recipes

The horizontal dash arrives late for a design reason: it is the only thing that creates momentum out of nothing. Before having it, the player is forced to draw their speed from the level; afterwards, they can manufacture it. That reopens the whole earlier map and is what justifies the route's backtracking stops.

The hook in detail

The hook works like a **real rope, of fixed length (4 m)**, tied to the anchor. Holding the button hooks the first anchor that comes within range (5 m): up close the chain stays slack, from far away it reels in to its length. Gravity swings you and **the rope only pulls, it never pushes**: at the top with no speed it goes slack and you drop straight down until it catches you again.

It is the most useful mechanic in the game, and **building momentum with it has to feel comfortable** (the reference is the web-swinging in PS4's Spider-Man). That is why it is forgiving: the stick swings you like a playground swing (up to 16 m/s), when it snaps taut you keep part of your speed, and **when you let go you leave with at least 90% of the speed you came in with**, in the direction you were moving. While hanging there is no air resistance.

At high speed the exit snaps to eight fixed directions (fully from 25 m/s), for stability; at low speed you leave freely, for versatility. If the stick points within 40° of your movement, you leave exactly toward the stick. Letting go upward comes with an instant of no gravity or resistance. Pressing a form while hanging releases you and the form fires immediately; if you keep holding the button, you hook again when it ends.

Anchors only exist where the designer places them: the hook is authorized geometry, not a free tool.

The laser

A harvesting tool, not a movement tool. Mining opens a short button combo that has to be completed in very little time; nailing it completely yields double what nailing it halfway does. Once upgraded it can go through obstacles and deal damage.

Combo harvesting only happens in **rest areas**, after a chase, a puzzle or a fight, as a reward. Whatever you find while exploring is cut instantly with a shot, no combo. That way mining never interrupts the rhythm: either you are fast and pick

things up on the way, or you have already stopped and the combo is the prize.

Fusion

Combining two forms into a new ability. It is a normal progression unlock, not a moral reward: it is learned in the Gamarra labs (stop 6), the biome where secrets are revealed and tools are discovered. With three forms, and order not mattering, there are **three fusions**: Circle+Square, Circle+Triangle and Square+Triangle.

The design requirement: a fusion has to behave like an ability quite different from its base forms, not like an improved version of them. If the Circle+Square fusion feels like a slightly stronger Circle, it doesn't deserve the button or the clutch.

The clutch

It is activated with **L2**, which works like a clutch: you hold it down and choose the two forms with their own buttons.

The first time you discover a combination, time stops until you perform it. That is three moments in the whole game, one per fusion, and each one is a set piece. After that it works like the bow in *Breath of the Wild*: you go into slow motion and time gradually returns to real speed on its own. The window closes by itself, so hesitating has an expiry date.

Friction runs in real time during the slow motion. You watch your own speed bleed while you decide. Both pressures push toward the same thing: choose now. If the window closes with no selection, nothing else happens: the punishment is already the lost momentum and the broken tempo. Since choosing takes two presses, the window can be short (half a second) and still feel generous.

Economy

The principle that holds up the two starting charges

> **Charges amplify momentum; they never sustain it. Any stop has to be traversable with geometry alone.** If running out of charges kills a run, that is a level bug, not a tuning bug.

With that rule, starting with two charges stops being a punishment and becomes what teaches you to read the level. The ceiling of five, at the end, is what allows long combos and returning to places that were closed before.

Four resources with four functions that don't overlap:

RESOURCE	WHAT IT IS	HOW YOU GET IT
Charges	Fuel for the forms. They start at 2, ceiling 5. They regenerate 1 every 1.5 s	Getting close to a prism and taking part of its energy
Prisms	Fuel for the ship. Taking all three means being able to leave	1 and 2 arrive through the story; 3 is a choice
Ashlar	The mineral that repels the prisms' frequency	Ice biome
Hook	Starting fuel that is crafted, and later grip upgrades	The Guardians' Glyco-Silk

The separation between touching the prism and taking it is the key piece of the game's whole moral economy. Touching it gives you the charge and never costs anything: the progression you need to play is never at stake. Taking it doesn't make you stronger; it decides whether you can leave the planet.

Inventory and expedition

Prismo's inventory is a **backpack with limited capacity**. Everything you pick up travels with you until you reach a base and deposit it, and what you are carrying when you die is what you lose.

You can only craft with deposited material. Until the material reaches a base it is worth nothing, so going back isn't maintenance: it is the step that turns loot into progress.

From there comes the **expedition loop**: you go out, fill the backpack, and at some point decide between the way back or paying resources to send the cargo remotely. A one-button decision instead of a walk, which is what fits a momentum game. The reverse delivery also fits: asking for material to be delivered to you at a specific point. The dial of this economy is the backpack's capacity, which is a suit upgrade.

Progression: the two key systems

Basic movement is not gated: the three forms are available from minute one. On top of that base there are two lock systems that feed each other.

System A: what you build

The key isn't found: it is manufactured. The lock is solved by getting resources, and that is a lock the player can always attack by exploring.

- **World infrastructure:** bridges, cable cars, passages. They modify the map permanently.
- **Suit augments:** permanent, cumulative upgrades, in the vein of *Metroid Dread*'s suit upgrades. Environmental resistances (cold, radiation, acid) and gameplay additions.
- **Bases:** they are founded and upgraded, and they open fast travel between biomes.

System B: what you are given

- **New abilities:** hook, double jump, horizontal dash.
- **Charge capacity:** from 2 to 5, touching the three prisms. More charges means longer combos, and longer combos reach places that were impossible before.

Charge capacity is a real gate. A stop that demands chaining four forms in a row is inaccessible with a ceiling of two, and no amount of skill makes up for it. Since charges regenerate on their own, they are never scarce before an attempt, only during one: they are not an economy, they are a combo length limit, how many moves fit in a single breath. **The unit of level design is how many charges there are between two safe footholds.**

Ship fragments are memory fragments

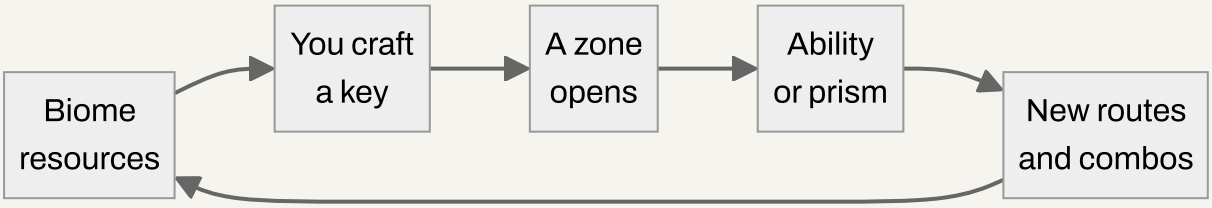
Prismo collects the pieces of its ship across the biomes, and each piece gives it back a memory. Some biome zones also teach it what has happened in this world.

The collectible that unlocks the ending is also the one that tells the story. The player rebuilds the ship, Prismo's memory and the truth about the planet at the same time, and all three bars advance with the same act. The AI is repaired at the same pace, so its amnesia and the player's heal together.

That is why the central revelation doesn't happen in one specific scene: Prismo gradually pieces together that its civilization ruins worlds, and the moment it fully understands depends on how it explored.

How they interlock

The two systems alternate. A door from system A leads to a key from system B, which opens a door leading to another key, and so on.



With crafting only, the player gets stuck farming. With abilities only, they get stuck waiting for an item. Alternating, there are always two fronts open and at least one actionable.

The playthrough curve

STOPS	CHARGES	KIT	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
1	2	3 forms + hook	Learning to draw speed from the level. Every charge counts
2–5	3	+ double jump, resistances	Vertical routes. Useful backtracking begins

STOPS	CHARGES	KIT	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE
6	4	+ Fusion	Longer combos and the first truly new toy
7–13	5	+ horizontal dash	Full kit. The player manufactures their own momentum and the whole earlier map reopens

The jump from 4 to 5 at stop 7 leaves six stops with the full kit, which are exactly the ones that concentrate the dense basalt zone, the three revisits and the climax.

Bases

The places where a base can be built are **fixed and specific**, and each one requires the biome's local materials. When you reach one, the AI points it out: *"look, this place is perfect for a base, let's build one here!"*. A freshly founded base doesn't do anything yet: what turns it into a base are the upgrades.

Major upgrades: what makes a base a base

UPGRADE	WHAT IT ENABLES
Replicator	Restores health and other values, saves the game, duplicates Prismo on death and sets its last zone
Fabricator	Allows crafting

Minor upgrades: behaviour and connection between bases

UPGRADE	WHAT IT ENABLES
Transporter	Moves Prismo from one base to another, at a cost proportional to the distance
Mini Bases	Save and respawn points spread across the biome, in fixed spots. They don't store or craft. The *Hollow Knight* bench model

Visual upgrades: decoration for each base inspired by its biome.

Base placement is the game's difficulty dial

If the base is the resurrection point and the only place where material is safe, then **the distance between the base and the danger sets a zone's real difficulty.** Not the enemies, not the hazards, not the numbers.

A deadly zone 20 seconds from a base is tense. The same zone three minutes away is frustrating, with the same hazards. Fixed spots, Mini Bases included, keep that dial in the design's hands: each mini base is an explicit decision about where a biome's tension resets, and placing it twenty seconds or three minutes before a deadly stretch completely changes what that stretch means.

Death and risk

Prismo is a clone, and death uses that fact instead of hiding it.

On reaching 0%: **the backpack stays on the spot, the body disappears, and at the last base visited a new body is manufactured and the memories are reinstalled.** All material that wasn't stored in a base is lost. The backpack can be recovered if the player finds it again. Health is a percentage: 100% at base, expandable up to 150% with Suit Coverage.

It is a corpse-run with a diegetic justification, and it solves three things at once:

- **It gives weight to the economy.** Going back to base to deposit becomes a risk decision: do I keep going with a full backpack or do I secure what I carry.
- **It gives weight to speed.** Damage scales with m/s, so running with a loaded backpack is exactly the moment you have the most to lose.
- **It feeds the narrative.** Every death repeats in miniature what Prismo is: disposable material from a civilization that manufactures clones. The player lives it before anyone tells them.

Backpacks don't pile up into one: each one stays where it was dropped, up to a maximum of three at once. The player can have three corpses spread across the world and decide which one to go back to first. That turns recovery into a route to plan instead of a repeated punishment, and it fits a game where dying twice in a row is a matter of seconds.

The backpacks you never recovered don't disappear entirely: a mole mini-boss in Gamarra keeps them as treasure. It turns your worst moments into concrete loot, it gives the Moles a reason to exist consistent with being scavengers, and it rewards the player who has suffered the most.

Encounters

There is no separate combat system. Every encounter is solved with the movement vocabulary the player already has.

Themed enemies

Each enemy is a lock that asks for a specific form. They are one-move puzzles, not duels.

TYPE	HOW IT IS SOLVED
Crystalline body	Laser, to shatter it
Heavy shell	Square, arriving with enough speed
Drillable body	Triangle, going through it

Each new enemy reuses and reinforces an existing ability instead of asking for new systems.

Bosses as chases

Bosses are not turn-based duels but **chase sections**. A static boss would force you to slow down exactly at the moment of highest tension, and slowing down is the opposite of what the game rewards. A chase is the core's natural showcase: it forces you to chain forms under pressure, with no room to think slowly.

- **The Moles (stop 6).** Scrappers who experiment with a prism protected by Ashlar. They dig to escape, so the chase goes downward and through tunnels.
- **A Child (stops 1 and 13).** They launch themselves erratically through the air following any bright light, without weighing the risk. The Guardians invented the hook precisely to keep up with them, so chasing a Child is the hook tutorial, and at the end of the game the same chase means something completely different.

Dungeons and puzzle zones

Authored spaces where the game's two axes cross: they are solved by crafting objects and infrastructure and using stored speed to open the way. They are the place where crafting stops being a background economy and becomes a gameplay verb. The basalt biome (stop 8) has the highest density of them.

Common enemies

They are obstacles, not things to defeat: **moving hazards** that are dodged, repelled with the Square or crossed with momentum. None of them has a health bar: enemies with health would bring a whole combat system to compete with movement.

The Moles are the surface antagonist

The game's only real threat is the Children growing up, and the player doesn't understand that until stop 13. The Moles give a face to the first half of the game without inventing a line of lore:

STOP	WHAT THEY DO
1	Shadows that flee. You see them stealing minerals and digging to escape
Variable	A mole mini-boss keeps the backpacks you never recovered as treasure
6	Boss. They experiment with a prism protected by Ashlar, without understanding what they have

From anonymous thieves to "these have my stuff" to "these are playing with something that killed a city".

Interface

The HUD is diegetic: everything lives on Prismo's suit, not on a floating layer.

ELEMENT	WHAT IT SHOWS
Speed meter	The main reading. It surrounds the character
HP %	Health as a percentage
Charges	How many are left and how long until the next one
Multifunction screen	Temporary states, top speed reached and Prismo's face

Controls

PlayStation controller as the reference.

PlayStation's buttons are named like the forms. Triangle does Triangle, Square does Square, Circle does Circle: a mnemonic that makes the game teach itself. To protect it on the other platforms, **the UI uses the shape as the prompt glyph on all of them**: it never writes "Y" or the word triangle, it draws △. On top of that it gives a consistent icon language for the HUD, tutorials and level design: a △ painted on a wall explains that it is drillable terrain without a single word.

INPUT	ACTION
Left stick	Movement and aiming the forms (8 directions)
Left stick up	Interact, and free camera when there is nothing to interact with
Triangle	Triangle form
Square	Square form
Circle	Circle form
X	Jump / double jump
R2	Hook
R1	Dash
L2	Fusion (clutch)
L1	Laser
D-pad	Menus: inventory, map, holograms

Interacting and looking share a stick, as in *Hollow Knight*. If there is something to interact with, you interact; if not, the camera pans in that direction so you can scout before committing to a fast jump. It doesn't clash with aiming the forms because the direction is only read at the instant you press a form. The free camera is limited to low speed: at high speed the camera is already zooming and leading automatically.

The multifunction screen

It works like a smartwatch on the suit's chest, and it changes depending on what is happening: health, a counter of temporary states, and the top speed reached as a reward to read. **When there is nothing to show, it shows Prismo's face**: the HUD becomes a character and gives a constant channel of expression without spending body animation.

The face is where corruption lives

The corruption from taking the prisms is not shown in the world or on the suit. **It is shown here:** Prismo's face looks more and more exhausted, more irritated. It is a narrative change, not a meter.

That makes the multifunction screen the only channel for the game's main thematic arc. So that the player reads it, the face also reacts to speed and danger, and it learns to be read before it has something serious to say. Since the prisms decide the ending and don't grant power, the corruption doesn't need a mechanical cost for the decision to weigh.

Camera

The camera has two opposite jobs and they are solved separately:

- **Exploration:** a close, calm framing, *Hollow Knight* style.
- **Speed and puzzles:** it pulls back and looks ahead as momentum rises.

The second one is not decoration. At high speed a tight camera makes the game unreadable, and the player would stop committing to speed exactly when the game starts to work.